

Coping styles:

Lazarus and Folkman's transactional model of stress appraisal is the most widely known and used model within coping research. Coping is defined as 'constantly changing cognitive and behavioural efforts to manage specific external and/or internal demands that are appraised to be taxing or exceeding the resources of the person', (Lazarus and Folkman, 1984, as cited in Cheavens and Dreer, 2009: 233).

Primary appraisal is the extent to which individuals perceive their situation to be threatening. Secondary appraisal is an individual's perception of whether or not they have the resources available to them to deal with the stressor.

There are two main coping strategies that individuals use when faced with stressful or adverse situations. Problem-focused coping is when people identify the stressor and take active steps to engage with and tackle the issues at hand. Emotion-focused coping is when individuals tend to focus on dealing with the emotions surrounding the situation, rather than attempting to change or deal with the situation. Emotion-focused coping tends to consist of turning to others and seeking social support. This type of coping includes avoidance, which is when an individual ignores the situation at hand and avoids any interaction with solving the issue (Collins et al., 1990; Urcuyo et al., 2005; Thornton and Perez, 2006).

Earlier research posited that problem-focused coping was the better form of coping; however, newer research shows that emotion-focused coping can indeed have positive consequences. For example, avoidance was once seen as a negative coping strategy although we now know that, in the short term, engaging in healthy distractions can be a good thing for people who have experienced significant trauma (Reynolds and Kee Hean, 2007).

Discovering the Adaptive Potential of Emotion-Focused Coping Intense emotions were seen as dysfunctional and opposed to rationality. Research in the 20th century often supported this view of emotional experiences by linking them with maladaptive outcomes in life. Annette Stanton, a positive psychologist at the University of California at Los Angeles, considered the adaptive potential of emotion-focused coping (i.e., regulating the emotions surrounding a stressful encounter), she found that there was a problem in how emotions were defined and measured in some of the research. Stanton, Danoff-Burg, Cameron, and Ellis (1994) found that scales assessing emotion-focused coping contained items in which the respondent had to engage in self-deprecation or admit to having distress or psychopathology whenever he or she acknowledged experiencing intense emotion. Responses to items such as "I blame myself for becoming too emotional" and "I get upset and let my emotions out" most probably would have been positively correlated with responses to items about a negative view of self or about general distress.

What is Emotion-Focused Coping? Stanton, Paras, and Austenfeld (2002) stated that "coping through emotional approach might be said to carry adaptive potential, the realization of which may depend on

the situational context, the inter-personal milieu, and attributes of the individual.” What they call emotional approach involves active movement toward, rather than away from, a stressful encounter.

This distinction between emotional approach and emotional avoidance is supported by the existence of two neurobiological systems that govern approach (i.e., appetitive) and avoidance behavior. The behavioral activation system regulates our appetitive motivation, which helps us realize emotional or behavioral rewards, whereas the behavioral inhibition system functions to help us avoid negative events and punishment (Depue, 1996).

Stanton, Kirk, Cameron, and Danoff-Burg (2000) identified two related but distinct processes involved in approach-oriented emotion-focused coping.

1. Involves emotional processing, or attempts to understand emotions, and a
2. Reflects emotional expression, or free and intentional displays of feeling.

The researchers then created scales to tap these two approaches of emotional processing and emotional expression (see Table 7.1 for a list of components of the two processes).

Emotional Processing:

Emotional Processing or attempt to understand emotions include:

I realize that my feelings are valid and important.

I take time to figure out what I am really feeling.

I delve into my feelings to get a thorough understanding of them.

I acknowledge my emotions.

Emotional Expression:

Emotional expression or free and intentional displays of feeling include:

I feel free to express my emotions.

I take time to express my emotions.

I allow myself to express my feelings.

I let my feelings come out freely.

Research on Functions of Emotional Approach:

With emotion-focused coping defined and measured more clearly and objectively, Stanton and colleagues (Stanton et al., 2000; Stanton, Danoff-Burg, & Huggins, 2002) were able to illuminate the functions of emotional approach. Using their revised measures, Stanton et al. (2000) studied the impact of emotion-focused coping on women’s adjustment to breast cancer. Over a 3- month period, women who used emotion-focused coping perceived their health status as better, had lower psychological distress, and had fewer medical appointments for cancer-related pain and ailments, as compared to those who did not.

Working with an undergraduate population, Stanton and colleagues (2000) found that students who were dealing with a parent's psychological or physical illness coped better with their stressors if they were assigned to sessions that matched their emotional approach tendencies. S

Advantages of Emotional Coping

Functions of Emotional Approach:

This coping approach may foster a better understanding of our experiences and direct our attention to central concerns (Frijda, 1994). Furthermore, over time we may develop the tendency to face our stressors directly and repeatedly (instead of avoiding them on occasion) and thereby habituate to certain predictable negative experiences.

Emotion-focused coping may be a key component related to medical issues such as cardiac stress. In a study examining different types of coping as predictors of disease severity of acute coronary syndrome, patients who used emotion-focused coping had less severity overall. The researchers hypothesize that emotion-focused coping may moderate certain physiological responses to a stressful event such that the heart has reduced reactivity to stress (Chiavarino et al., 2012). This research has great implications for creating psychological interventions in those who show symptoms of diseases related to stress reactions.

The benefits of emotion-focused coping styles may have mediating qualities as well. Other researchers have found that, when dealing with the stress of chronic racism, racial and ethnic minority individuals' positive appraisal of emotion-focused coping options may intervene in the relationship between self-esteem, life satisfaction, and racial identity development (Outten, Schmitt, Garcia, & Branscombe, 2009; Peters, 2006). Specifically, when individuals of racial and ethnic minority groups feel that they have ways of coping emotionally with experiences of discrimination, greater self-esteem and greater life satisfaction were more closely linked with a strong identification with their racial group (Outten et al., 2009). It may be that when a victim of racism feels the negative effects of being associated with a group that is seen to be at a disadvantage, being able to use positive reframing helps the individual to retain good feelings about himself or herself and the groups to which he or she belongs. One way of coping utilized in cases of discrimination is a strong identification with others in one's own ethnic group. This type of identification, used as a form of coping, has been found to foster psychological well-being (Giamo, Schmitt, & Outten, 2012). In other research, Peters (2006) found that in an African American sample, emotion-focused coping was negatively correlated with the experience of chronic stress emotions as brought on by exposure to racism. These results point to the conclusion that use of emotion-focused styles of coping to deal with stressors related to personal racism, or as part of a racial group, may increase well-being and/or decrease stress for individuals experiencing these types of stressors in their environments (Outten et al.).

Work on emotion-focused coping, summarized in a review by Austenfeld and Stanton (2004), highlights the adaptive potential of emotional expression and processing when coping with infertility, cancer, and chronic pain. Anecdotal evidence collected from the reports of our clients and friends suggests that the adaptive potential of emotional approach also is realized in normal life circumstances. For instance, each

day we are challenged by minor stresses (junk mail, schedule changes, traffic) and real problems (shortages of money, minor illnesses, subtle prejudices) that stir up emotions that we can approach or avoid. Many people within a Western context seem to benefit, at least in the short run, from expressing their emotions in a meaningful way. Further, emotional processing seems to become more adaptive as people learn more about what they feel and why they feel it (Stanton, Sullivan, & Austenfeld, 2009).

This is not always the case, however. Specifically, many Asian cultures encourage suppression of emotions, as opposed to expression, with the goal of preserving harmony in the group (Chiang, 2012; Lee, 2013; Murata, Moser, & Kitayama, 2013). Recent studies show that even today emotional suppression is common in Chinese individuals and is not necessarily associated with the same negative correlates found in Western studies (Chiang, 2012). This said, there may be some circumstances, such as within close personal relationships, where emotional expression is considered by Asians to be appropriate and healthy. Contemporary Asian individuals may use a mixture of emotion suppression (culturally normative in traditional Asian culture) and emotional expression (culturally normative in more contemporary Asian culture, which is influenced by Western values). In situations where Asians are expected to emote expressively, they may feel stress at not wanting to do this. On the other hand, they may also feel stress in contexts where they should suppress but have a desire to emote. In this way, “This cultural complexity may result in value conflict whereby some Asians may become emotionally ambivalent when their expressive styles clash with different sociocultural norms” (Lee, 2013, p. 171). Different coping strategies may be used in these cultural groups to combat this stress.

Given the robust findings linking emotion-focused coping and adaptive outcomes under particular circumstances, it is important to understand how emotional approach works to our benefit. Of course, if we turned our attentions away from unpleasant feelings each time we experienced them, we would learn very little about how these feelings influence us and our friends (Salovey, Mayer, & Caruso, 2002). This approach to coping may foster a better understanding of our experiences and direct our attention to central concerns (Frijda, 1994). Furthermore, over time we may develop the tendency to face our stressors directly and repeatedly (instead of avoiding them on occasion) and thereby habituate to certain predictable negative experiences. We learn that emotional pain does subside, and time heals both psychological and physical wounds. As we discuss later in this chapter, understanding our emotional experience can help us select optimal relationships and environments (Carstensen, 1998), particularly when we consider the norms in our own cultural context. On a neurobiological level, Depue (1996) points to the involvement of the behavioral activation system, and LeDoux (1996) reveals that a particular brain structure, the amygdala, plays a significant role in processing matters of emotional significance. Specifically, LeDoux suggests that, under stress-free life circumstances, our thinking is governed by the hippocampus, but, during more stressful times, our thought processes—and hence aspects of our coping—are ruled by the amygdala. Interestingly, culture may even affect individuals at the neurological level to some extent. In comparing Asian individuals to European American individuals a study found that Asians seem to be “culturally trained to down-regulate emotional processing when required to suppress emotion” (Murata et al., 2013, p. 595). Researchers in this study measured levels of emotional processing at a neurological level and found that when asked to suppress their reactions to negative pictures, Asians were able to decrease their neurological reaction to such a picture. European

Americans in comparison did not seem to be able to control this in the same way. This provides intriguing information for potential environmental control on neurological response. Future examination of the neurobiology of emotion-focused coping and emotional processing may further demystify the potential benefits of approaching or avoiding emotions and the related workings of brain structures such as the amygdala.

Neurobiological Basis of Emotional Responses

On the neurobiological level, Depue (1996) points to the involvement of the behavioural activation system, and LeDoux (1996) reveals that a particular brain structure, the amygdale, plays a significant role in processing matters of emotional significance. Specifically, LeDoux suggests that, under stress-free life circumstances, our thinking is governed by the hippocampus, but during more stressful times, our thought processes-and hence aspects of our coping-are ruled by the amygdale.

Cases of Hurricane and Earthquake Survivors

While standing in a line for earthquake relief with dozen of survivors, One psychologist witnessed people who were avoiding all emotions, some who were approaching their emotions productively, and some who were frankly overwhelmed by what they were experiencing. It was seen that those who were approaching their emotions are doing better today than those who did not.

- **The neurobiological basis of emotional responses** involves complex interactions within the brain and the nervous system. Emotions are multifaceted experiences that encompass a range of feelings such as happiness, fear, anger, sadness, and more. Understanding the neural mechanisms underlying emotional responses is a subject of ongoing research, and while there is much that we know, there is also a lot that remains to be explored.

Here are some key components of the neurobiological basis of emotional responses:

Brain Structures: Several brain structures play crucial roles in emotional processing. The amygdala is a key player and is often associated with the processing of fear and other emotions. The hippocampus is involved in memory formation and has connections to emotional responses. The prefrontal cortex, especially the ventromedial prefrontal cortex, is implicated in decision-making and emotional regulation.

Neurotransmitters: Chemical messengers called neurotransmitters play a vital role in transmitting signals between neurons. Serotonin, dopamine, norepinephrine, and others are neurotransmitters associated with mood and emotion regulation. Imbalances in these neurotransmitters can contribute to mood disorders.

Hormones: Hormones, such as cortisol and adrenaline (epinephrine), are released during stress and play a role in the fight-or-flight response. Oxytocin, often referred to as the "love hormone," is associated with social bonding and attachment.

Neural Circuits: Emotional responses involve complex neural circuits that connect different brain regions. These circuits facilitate the processing and integration of sensory information, emotional experience, and behavioral responses.

Limbic System: The limbic system is a group of interconnected structures in the brain that are involved in emotion, motivation, and memory. It includes the amygdala, hippocampus, thalamus, hypothalamus, and others.

Cognitive Appraisal: Emotions are influenced by cognitive processes, including the appraisal of a situation. How an individual interprets and evaluates a situation can shape their emotional response.

Genetics: There is evidence to suggest that genetic factors can influence emotional responses. Certain genetic variations may predispose individuals to be more or less susceptible to certain emotional disorders.

Plasticity and Adaptation: The brain exhibits neuroplasticity, meaning it can adapt and reorganize in response to experiences. Emotional experiences can lead to changes in neural circuits and structures over time.

